MBA: 8109 RESEARCH METHODS



Week 6: Negotiating Access and Research Ethics

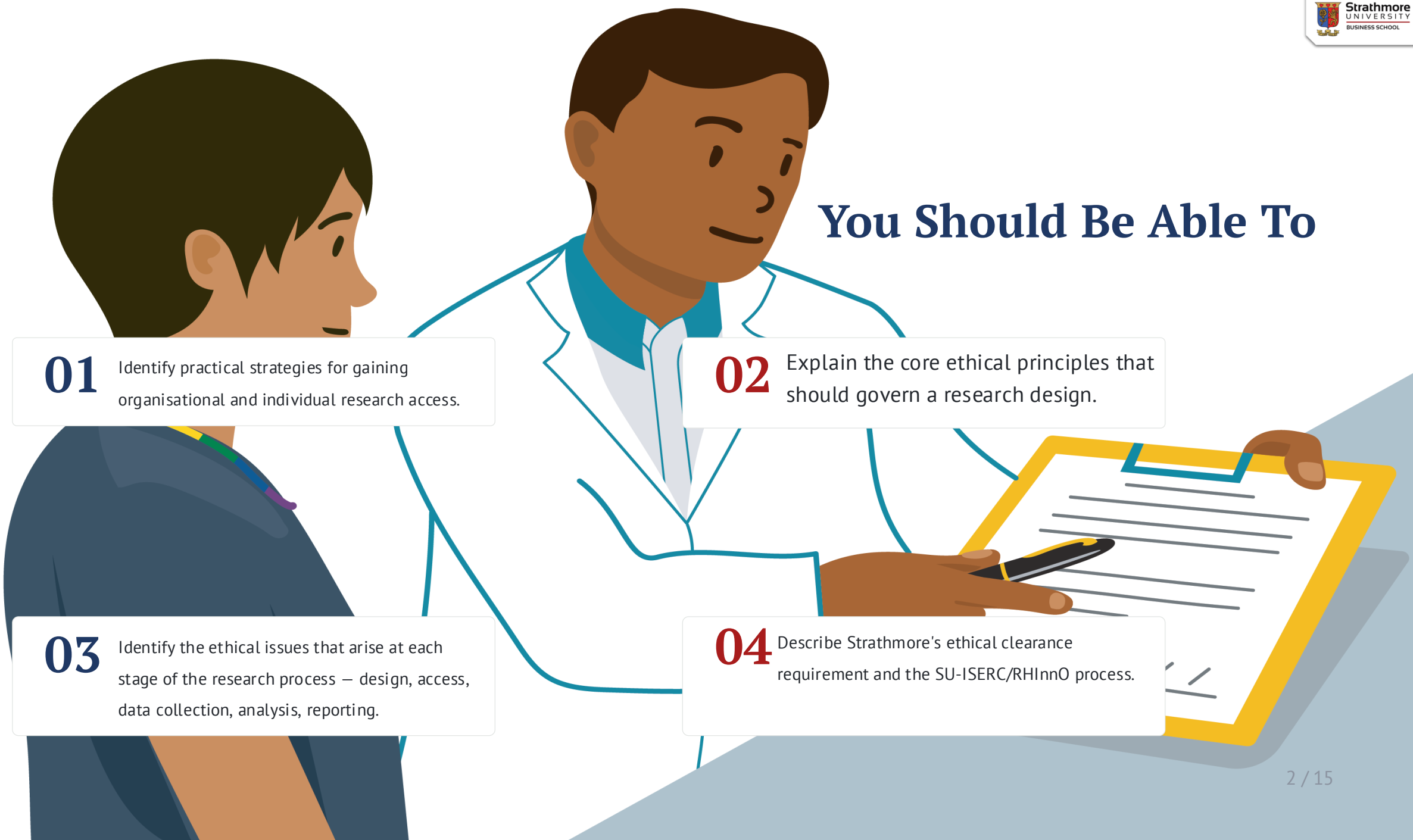
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Strathmore Business School | MBA Evening 2026, Trimester II

You Should Be Able To



01 Identify practical strategies for gaining organisational and individual research access.

02 Explain the core ethical principles that should govern a research design.

03 Identify the ethical issues that arise at each stage of the research process — design, access, data collection, analysis, reporting.

04 Describe Strathmore's ethical clearance requirement and the SU-ISERC/RHInnO process.

THE ETHICS FOUNDATION

Why Ethics? Why It Matters to Your Research

Ethics refers to **"norms or standards of behaviour that guide moral choices about our behaviour and our relationships with others"** (Cooper & Schindler, 2008).



THE CORNERSTONE PRINCIPLE

Avoidance of harm — non-maleficence

Every choice — how you obtain consent, preserve confidentiality, collect, analyse and report data — has the capacity to cause harm to participants, and to you as the researcher.

It governs how you formulate your topic, design the study, gain access, collect, store, analyse and report data — in a way that is both methodologically sound and morally defensible.

THE ETHICS FOUNDATION

A Brief History of Research Ethics

1947

Nuremberg Code

Post-war trials over Nazi medical experiments establish voluntary, informed consent as the first codified research principle.

1964

Declaration of Helsinki

World Medical Association statement of ethical principles for research involving human subjects; revised repeatedly since.

1972

Tuskegee Study Exposed

Decades of withheld treatment come to light in the US, becoming the strongest public case for formal ethics oversight.

1979

The Belmont Report

Three principles — respect for persons, beneficence, justice — become the basis of modern ethics review, including SU-IERC's own mandate.

THE ETHICS FOUNDATION

The Major Ethical Principles

Principle	What it means for your study
Privacy	Respect participants' right not to take part, and not to be approached in intrusive or coercive ways.
Voluntary participation	No coercion or inducement beyond reasonable expenses; participants may withdraw at any time, in whole or in part.
Informed consent	Consent must be freely given and based on full information — not implied, and never obtained through deception.
Avoidance of harm	The cornerstone principle (non-maleficence) — guard against embarrassment, stress, discomfort, pain and harm.
Confidentiality & anonymity	Once promised, must be maintained — in names, quotes, organisational detail and even indirect identification.
Objectivity	Collect, analyse and report data accurately and fully, without selective reporting or fabrication.

These trace to the Belmont triad — respect for persons, beneficence, justice — and sit within two stances: **deontological** (the ends never justify unethical means) or **teleological** (benefits are weighed against the costs of acting unethically).

NEGOTIATING ACCESS

Access Is Not One Event — It's a Continuing Process



1 Physical access

Entry itself — granted formally through management, or an organisational gatekeeper/broker.

2 Cognitive access

Genuine acceptance and consent from participants — the data they are willing and able to provide.

3 Continuing access

Often iterative — you may need to renegotiate access for each new part or phase of the study.

NEGOTIATING ACCESS

Strategies for Gaining Access — and Overcoming Barriers

Strategies that work

- Identify the gatekeeper who actually controls access
- Use existing contacts; build new ones where needed
- Establish credibility with a clear, professional case
- Check feasibility & sufficiency before you commit
- Offer something in return — e.g. a summary report
- Allow sufficient time — access is often iterative

Barriers — and your ethical response

- Time/resource cost to the organisation → be realistic in what you ask
- Topic sensitivity or confidentiality worries → give firm assurances
- Doubts about your credibility → a considered introduction
- Any refusal → accept it fully; never pressure or coerce



ETHICS THROUGH THE PROCESS

Ethical Issues at Every Stage of Your Research

Stage	Key ethical concerns
Design & gaining access	Absence of sponsor/gatekeeper coercion, being fully informed, privacy, research quality
Data collection	Informed consent, right to withdraw, deception, researcher safety, confidentiality/anonymity
Processing & storing data	Participants' rights over how their personal data are processed and stored
Analysis, reporting & dissemination	Objectivity, avoiding harm through identification, honest and complete reporting



Where Ethics Gets Tested: During Data Collection

Stay within agreed scope
Keep to the aims you shared; widening scope without renegotiating is a form of deceit.

Right to withdraw
Participants may decline any part, or withdraw entirely, at any point — before starting.

Guard against harm
Watch for embarrassment, stress, discomfort and pain — especially in interviews and observation.

Protect data as you collect
Confidentiality/anonymity promises must hold immediately — anonymise as you go, not only at write-up.

Your own safety
Never let your research design put you at risk — be deliberate about timing, location and being alone.

Covert research — a last resort
Only where reactivity would distort findings, or open access is refused and a covert presence is practical.

ETHICS THROUGH THE PROCESS

Analysis, Reporting & Dissemination: Where Integrity Is Tested

QUESTIONABLE RESEARCH PRACTICES

- **p-hacking** — reworking analyses, or stopping data collection, once results turn significant
- **HARKing** — presenting a post-hoc finding as if it were your original hypothesis
- **Cherry-picking** — selectively reporting only the results that fit your narrative
- **Fabrication & falsification** — inventing or altering data — a line never crossed

PUBLICATION & DISSEMINATION ETHICS

- **Gift, ghost & guest authorship** — credit added, withheld, or inflated without real contribution
- **Salami slicing** — splitting one study into multiple thin papers to inflate output
- **Duplicate / redundant publication** — republishing substantially the same work as if new
- **Plagiarism & undisclosed conflicts of interest** — using others' work, or a funding tie, without attribution

ETHICS THROUGH THE PROCESS

Informed Consent Is a Continuum, Not a Checkbox

Lack of consent

Deception is used to collect data; the participant lacks knowledge.

Implied consent

Consent is inferred — e.g. from access being granted, or a questionnaire being returned.

Informed consent

Freely given, based on full information about rights and use of data.

A GOOD INFORMATION SHEET / CONSENT FORM COVERS

Purpose of the study · What participation involves and its voluntary nature · Risks and expected benefits · Assurances on anonymity and confidentiality · Who will access the data and how findings will be disseminated · A named contact for questions



STRATHMORE'S ETHICAL CLEARANCE

The SU Institutional Ethics Review Committee (SU-IERC)

NACOSTI-accredited to review research protocols in the human and behavioural sciences.

The main committee reviews major-risk protocols (e.g. clinical trials); a subcommittee reviews minimal-risk postgraduate and undergraduate proposals.

Scientific approval is decentralised to schools and faculties — ethical clearance is separate, and both are required.

STATUTORY MANDATES INCLUDE

National Science & Technology Act (Cap 250, 1979) · ICH Good Clinical Practice Guidelines · Research Clearance in Kenya (NCST No. 15, 1984) · CIOMS (1985) · The Belmont Report

STRATHMORE'S ETHICAL CLEARANCE

RHInnO Ethics — the Online Protocol Management System

A Create your account

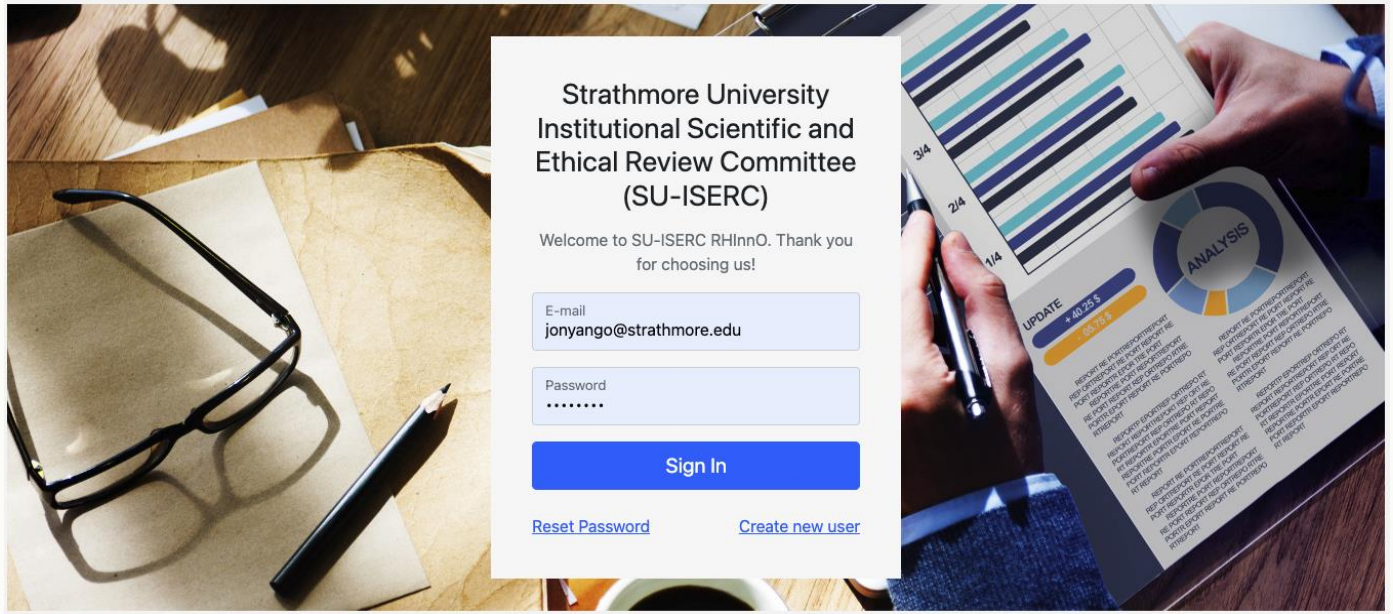
Register at strathmoreuniversity.rhinno.net

B Submit & track

Upload required documents; get immediate confirmation of a complete submission

C Review & approval

Cloud-based e-review with follow-up, from protocol to approval



Powered by:

RHInnO Ethics

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SU-IERC Checklist for Protocol Submission

Document	Postgraduate / undergraduate
Cover letter listing submitted documents	Required
Protocol / research proposal	Required
Subject information sheet & informed consent form(s)	Required
CVs for key personnel / investigators	Required
SU-IERC fee confirmation	Required — waived for SU students*
Conflict of interest declaration	Required
Evidence of Human Subject Protection training	Required
Questionnaires / diary cards	If applicable

*Strathmore students do not pay SU-IERC fees — the cost is covered by tuition. Clinical-trial-only items (Certificate of Analysis, Drug Brochure, Trial Insurance) do not apply to most postgraduate protocols.

IN-SESSION CLINIC

Your RHInnO Walkthrough — This Week

1. Open a RHInnO account at strathmoreuniversity.rhinno.net
2. Gather your draft proposal, CVs, and information sheet
3. Begin — but do not submit — a draft application in RHInnO
4. Bring questions to Saturday's clinic session

Looking ahead: your ethics thinking here feeds directly into Chapter 3 (Research Ethics) of your Concept Paper,